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What's Happening in the World of ACTS and CTPP

Our Winter 2025 newsletter introduced Julia Glickman as the new AASHTO Program Manager for Transportation Data, a position that includes managing the Census Transportation Planning Products (CTPP) program. (As a reminder, please see the last page of this newsletter for Julia's contact information.) The Fall 2024 in-person quarterly meeting of the AASHTO Census Transportation Solutions (ACTS) Oversight Board was followed by a virtual Winter quarterly board meeting held in December 2024. These meetings were described in the Winter newsletter and followed up with Spring and Summer 2025 quarterly meetings, described elsewhere in this issue. Of primary interest to our regular readers is the release of 2017–2021 CTPP data in March 2025, as described in the next article.

2017–2021 CTPP Data Released on New Data Portal!

The long awaited 2017–2021 CTPP data release can be accessed via the new CTPP data portal located here: <https://ctppdata.transportation.org/#/index>. A multi-step process is used to access the data:

- Step 1. Search and select a table – Use Data Table Filters and keywords to narrow down the search result. Entering more keywords will result in a shorter list of tables.
- STEP 2. Select a Geography – depending on the table selection, data might be available at the nation, state, county, place, tract, or block group level. Geographies not available for the specific table are greyed out. (Availability of data at the block group level is limited.) The user can select geographies either from a drop down listing or through a map interface.
- STEP 3. Retrieve Data Tables – clicking on the data retrieval button will bring up a table with the data and geography requested.
- STEP 4. Query Results – Your query can be saved and/or downloaded in .CSV, .XML, JSON, .SHP, or .TAB formats. A data visualization option is provided for users to generate charts depicting the data selection. Visualization options include a bar chart, column chart, column chart map, line chart, pie chart, or thematic map. Summary statistics can be obtained by total, average, median, minimum, maximum, variance and/or standard deviation. A data estimate is provided by default, along with margin of error (MOE). The user can toggle off the MOE and/or receive the variance of standard error, standard error, or MOE percent of estimate. Table info can also be depicted, and tables can be transposed, which is generally preferable for reporting purposes.

Do you want to conduct analysis of earlier CTPP data? No problem. On the first screen of the data portal, the user can select either the 2012-2016, 2006-2010, 2000, or the new 2017-2021 CTPP datasets.

The *CTPP Data Portal User Guide* can be accessed here for further instructions on how to navigate the new site: https://ctppdata.transportation.org/CTPP_DataPortal_UserGuide.pdf. Another document describing *2017 – 2021 Data Key Considerations for Users* can be downloaded here: https://ctppdata.transportation.org/2017_2021_Data_Key_Considerations.pdf. This document presents important background information on assumptions used for the 2017-2021 CTPP, along with a table that summarizes key differences between the 2017-2021 CTPP and 2012-2016 data. For those wanting a deeper dive into the process used to generate the latest dataset, a *CTPP Methodology Report* can be accessed here: https://ctppdata.transportation.org/CTPP_Methodology_Report.pdf.

Only the following custom extract data tables are available at the block group level:

1. Total Population
2. Means of Transportation to Work
3. Time of Departure To Go To Work

Another option, as previously reported in this newsletter, is to access the CTPP Data Application Programming Interface (API): <https://ctppdata.transportation.org/api-explorer.html>. The CTPP Data API is a data service that enables software developers to access and use CTPP data within their applications. As stated in the aforementioned User Guide, “the CTPP Data API (or API Explorer) is a powerful tool for visualizing and interacting with APIs described using the OpenAPI Specification (OAS).”

Recent ACTS Oversight Board Meeting Activities

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The ACTS Oversight Board held 2025 quarterly virtual meetings for Spring and Summer. Here are a few of the highlights from these two meetings:

- Abigail Butterick recently joined AASHTO in support of Julia Glickman, AASHTO Program Manager for Transportation Data.
- With the release of the 2017–2021 CTPP dataset and the new data portal, be on the lookout for additional outreach activities over the coming year.
- A special request to the Census Bureau is underway for the 2022-2026 CTPP tabulation to get into the queue.
- Efforts are underway on preparations for live CTPP training with anticipated readiness by October. New online training materials will also be forthcoming once live training is ready.
- Efforts continue with further testing of the new CTPP interface and addressing common questions and issues.
- The current CTPP table numbering is not systematic, so table renumbering is in the near future.
- Work is underway on developing and refining CTPP handout materials for distribution at future conferences.
- Research is anticipated on missing workplace location data and use of synthesized data. A report is expected on the use of CTPP data in planning processes.
- AASHTO staff are actively engaging with state DOTs to maximize funding participation in the CTPP program.
- Plans are underway for the next Census Data for Transportation Planning Conference, tentatively scheduled for June 1-4, 2026, in Providence, RI.
- In light of recent changes to the structure of TRB committees, the Board is looking at options to continue the work of the TRB AED20(1) Subcommittee: Census Data for Transportation Planning.
- Testing is underway to implement a “Chatbot” on the CTPP Data Portal. It is envisioned that this tool would be able to answer user questions and provide guidance as its knowledge base improves.
- AASHTO staff made a presentation on their platform called AASHTO Communities that has a document sharing feature.

The next ACTS Oversight Board meeting (2025 Q3) will be conducted in late October and the next *CTPP Status Report* will provide a synopsis.

2025 ACS Data Users Conference

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The 2025 ACS Data Users Conference, which was held virtually on May 29, 2025. The ACS (American Community Survey) is the source for CTPP tables. All presentations are available for downloading here: <https://acsdatacommunity.prb.org/p/conferences>. Here is a quick summary and highlights of ACS sessions of use to transportation planners.

- ACS Program Updates – this session went over recent and future changes to the ACS. Release dates were provided for 1- and 5-year products, along with upcoming webinar dates. An internet data collection instrument is now available for select non-institutional group quarters. A new address search provides a clickable list of Census Bureau geographies that an address falls within. Bar and column charts are now available for all ACS tables, along with statistical significance.
- Using the API – the ACS has its own API for interfacing ACS data with software programs and other datasets. Four presentations are posted online, along with a video of the session.
- Data Products Demonstration – this session includes demonstrations of the ACS website (top 5 things to know); Census website (single search, advanced search, and data visualization); microdata access tool (microdata overview, MDAT demo, learning resources); and the Census API (why use the API, geocoding, TIGERweb services). A video of the entire session is online.
- Synthetic Data – of the three presentations on this topic, *The Challenge of Synthetic Census Microdata: A Researcher Perspective* provides useful background information on the how, what, and why of microdata, including an interesting historical background.
- Lightning Session – 1 hour, 20 minutes for 8 quick presentations. As the ACS has a wide range of uses, only one of these presentations is directly relevant to transportation planning at a national level, titled *Remote Work and Productivity Growth 2019–2023*. As implied by the title, work from home was tracked across time and by job categories. Not surprisingly, the year 2021 showed the highest rates of remote work, with the highest levels being in professional, scientific, and technical services, followed closely by information, finance and insurance, and management. Across every industry, remote work was lowest in 2019, with a trend towards lower levels each year since 2021.
- Combining ACS with Other Survey or Administrative Data – the most relevant presentation of this session would likely be *Enhancing Population Estimates by Combining ACS and Local Data in Johnson County, KS*, as these techniques are applicable beyond this one example in the greater Kansas City region. In summary, the agency used ACS data for average household size and occupancy rates, while local data focused on parcel data for dwelling unit numbers and tenure (owner vs. renter occupied). Local data are updated daily using an automated nightly data sync to keep current.
- ACS Methods – there was an interesting presentation on *Testing Improvements To ACS Response*, describing two experimental tests underway, including an Internet-only instrument test and a questionnaire timing test; the Census Planning Database, described as the “Greatest hits” of ACS, was discussed, along with forthcoming PDB updates; the Administrative Records Data program (data collected from government agencies) was described in detail; and revisions to the Census Bureau’s low response score were documented in this session.
- Others – there were also sessions not directly related to transportation planning devoted to leveraging the ACS for specific outcomes, childcare and school enrollment, and housing. While there was a session on Using ACS Data for Planning, these presentations were not directly related to transportation planning.

The ACS Data Users Conference continues to be a great source of information on the how, why, what, and where of the ACS. As the latest conference was “all virtual,” it is highly recommended to participate

in future conferences. Please go to the aforementioned website for additional information and downloads.

Recent IPUMS Data Updates

IPUMS has been discussed in previous issues of the *CTPP Status Report*. For those who are unaware of IPUMS or need a refresher, “IPUMS democratizes access to the world’s social and economic data for current and future generations... IPUMS provides census and survey data from around the world integrated across time and space. IPUMS integration and documentation makes it easy to study change, conduct comparative research, merge information across data types, and analyze individuals within family and community context. Data and services are available free of charge.”

So, what’s new at IPUMS? Here’s a few select new announcements:

- The IPUMS Multigenerational Longitudinal Panel (MLP) has released version 2.0 of linked, full-count census data via IPUMS USA. This release increases the number of overall links and makes key improvements. Version 2.0 links are available via the IPUMS USA extract system.
<https://usa.ipums.org/usa/mlp/mlp.shtml>
- The 2024 American Time Use Survey (ATUS) data, released via IPUMS ATUS last week, have also been integrated into the Multinational Time Use Survey (MTUS) database.
<https://www.atusdata.org/atus/> <https://www.mtusdata.org/mtus/>
- IPUMS extended time series tables to include data from the 2020 Census DHC (Demographic and Housing Characteristics File). This release adds 2020 data to 215 existing tables and 13 new tables; it also adds nation, region, and division data for all source tables in five 1970 datasets and for 87 time series tables. <https://www.nhgis.org/time-series-tables>
- IPUMS has added June 2025 basic monthly Current Population Survey (CPS) data.
<https://cps.ipums.org/cps/>

It is worth noting that an alternative way to visualize ATUS data in a dashboard format is via [TMD / Home](#) where people can “explore mobility trends and patterns in the American Time Use Survey” for “a comprehensive analysis of travel behaviors using data from the American Time Use Survey ([ATUS](#))”.

The Steady Rise of the Nonemployer Businesses

According to the U.S. Census Bureau, “the total number of U.S. nonemployer establishments increased every year from 1997 to 2023 except during the financial crisis in 2008, according to the newly released Nonemployer Statistics. The U.S. Census Bureau data show annual growth of nonemployer establishments (those with no paid employees) almost always outpaced that of employer businesses (those with at least one paid employee). Nonemployers also represented a larger share of all U.S. businesses each year from 1997 to 2023.

From 2012 to 2023, the total number of nonemployers grew an average 2.7% annually, while employers averaged only 1.1% growth year-over-year. During this same timeframe, nonemployers’ share of all U.S. businesses grew by 3%, shrinking employers’ share from 24.6% to 21.6%.” More on this trend can be found in the full article here: https://www.census.gov/library/stories/2025/07/nonemployer-business-growth.html?utm_campaign=20250730aco&utm_medium=email&utm_source=govdelivery

"We Still Want To Be Together And Still Want To Meet Face-To-Face"

Guy Rousseau passed along a link to “The Future Of Where,” a twice weekly discussion that explores “how the whole idea of place, proximity, and location might be changing after COVID.” A recent episode includes a discussion on the extent to which telecommunications has replaced travel, between Bill Fulton, FAICP (a self-described “thought leader and speaker on cities and urban planning” and Professor of Practice at UC San Diego Department of Urban Studies and Planning) and Pat Mokhtarian, PhD

(Regents Professor and Clifford & William Greene, Jr. Professor of Civil & Environmental Engineering at Georgia Institute of Technology). You can click on the link below to access this discussion and subscribe to future dialogue: <https://futureofwhere.substack.com/p/we-still-want-to-be-together-and>

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- 2012-2016 CTPP Data: <https://ctppdata.transportation.dev/#/index>
- FHWA CTPP website: https://www.fhwa.dot.gov/planning/census_issues/ctpp/
- FHWA website for Census issues: https://www.fhwa.dot.gov/planning/census_issues/
- AASHTO website for CTPP: <https://ctpp.transportation.org>
- 1990 and 2000 CTPP data downloadable via Transtats: <https://transtats.bts.gov/>
- TRB Subcommittee on census data:
<https://transportation.org/ctpp/census-data-for-transportation-planning/>
- American Community Survey (ACS) Data Users Group: <https://acsdatacommunity.prb.org/>